
Context:

= Battle of Dürenstein =

The Battle of Dürenstein (also known as the Battle of <unk>, Battle of <unk> and Battle of <unk>; German: <unk> bei <unk>), on 11 November 1805 was an engagement in the Napoleonic Wars during the War of the Third Coalition. Dürenstein (modern <unk>) is located in the <unk> Valley, on the River Danube, 73 kilometers (45 mi) upstream from Vienna, Austria. The river makes a crescent-shaped curve between <unk> and nearby Krems an der Donau and the battle was fought in the flood plain between the river and the mountains. At Dürenstein a combined force of Russian and Austrian troops trapped a French division commanded by Théodore Maxime Gazan. The French division was part of the newly created VIII Corps, the so-called Corps Mortier, under command of Édouard Mortier. In pursuing the Austrian retreat from Bavaria, Mortier had over-extended his three divisions along the north bank of the Danube. Mikhail <unk> Kutuzov, commander of the Coalition force, enticed Mortier to send Gazan's division into a trap and French troops were caught in a valley between two Russian columns. They were rescued by the timely arrival of a second division, under command of Pierre Dupont de l'Étang. The battle extended well into the night. Both sides claimed victory. The French lost more than a third of their participants, and Gazan's division experienced over 40 percent losses. The Austrians and Russians also had heavy <unk> to 16 <unk> perhaps the most significant was the death in action of Johann Heinrich von Schmitt, one of Austria's most capable chiefs of staff. The battle was fought three weeks after the Austrian capitulation at Ulm and three weeks before the Russo-Austrian defeat at the Battle of Austerlitz. After Austerlitz Austria withdrew from the war. The French demanded a high indemnity and Francis II abdicated as Holy Roman Emperor, releasing the German states from their allegiance to the Holy Roman Empire.

= = Background = =

In a series of conflicts from 1803-15 known as the Napoleonic Wars, various European powers formed five coalitions against the First French Empire. Like the wars sparked by the French Revolution (1789), these further revolutionized the formation, organization and training of European armies and led to an unprecedented militarization, mainly due to mass conscription. Under the leadership of Napoleon, French power rose quickly as the Grande Armée conquered most of Europe, and collapsed rapidly

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after the French conquest of Italy. This victory marked the beginning of the Second Coalition. Napoleon's rapid advance caused Austria – Russia, Britain and Russia to make peace negotiations. The Russian army under Prince Mikhail Mikhailovich Mikhailovich Chaffee, commander of the Imperial Russian Army in Switzerland, was able to drive off the Austrians in the Battle of Stockach (1805) and to take Pressburg (modern Ö3 Austria) from the Austrians. At an early stage the Austro-Hungarian fleet had been damaged in a storm off Cape Matapan; this allowed the Allies to launch a full-scale invasion of Italy in February 1805. The Battle of Austerlitz was the decisive French victory against Napoleon and the largest naval battle in history, involving more modern-day European navies. The French military situation worsened as Napoleon faced several threats related to his newly formed Army of Europe, particularly Russia itself, which was now on the verge of collapse. The Russian general and friend of Napoleon, Alexander, had been dissatisfied with the conduct of the Austrians; he was still in conflict with Emperor Napoleon, the French Republic's king, who had declared war on Austria during the summer of 1804. With the war over, Napoleon decided to launch a second invasion of Italy in October 1805.

= = Prelude = =

In July 1805, the French 1st Army entered southern Italy. The army, under the command of Marshal Marmont, were reinforced by a few battalions of infantry under Claude General Auguste de Marmont at the town of Philippsburg and another battalion at Belluno. On 17 September 1805, the army marched from Belluno towards Krems. By 29 September, they had reached Belluno and conducted its advance against a small Austrian force. By 31 September, the whole force had been reinforced by a brigade from the Army of Tyrol under the command of Pierre Augereau. The Austrians were now under the command of Marshal Jean Victor Marie Moreau, a member of the Directory. Moreau had taken command of the Austrian invasion force in the spring of 1805. His command included the VI Corps commanded by Jean Baptiste Drouet de Ney and the VI Corps commanded by Generals Jean Victor Marie Moreau and Joseph Souham. Ney's corps consisted of the III. Corps and VI. Corps, which consisted of the III Corps and VI. Corps, located in the Austrian Netherlands, was commanded by Friedrich Joseph, Count Baillet de Latour. Moreau's army consisted of six divisions and several associated brigades.

= = Aftermath = =

= = = First Coalition forces = = =

On 9 October 1805 the French Army of the Danube was attacked by an Austrian army under Archduke Charles at the Battle of Austerlitz. Although Charles and Charles had not had much time to regroup, on 10 October, he launched his attack on the Polish forces under Friedrich Joseph, Count of Lauenburg. After three days, Charles' army captured Lauenburg. The French forces pursued the Austrians to the Silesian border, where they encountered strong Austrian resistance. These conflicts forced the Austrians to retreat into Tyrol and Austria agreed to a truce. The Austrian army, commanded by Wenzel Anton Karl, Count of Merveldt, was reduced to around 10,000 men. It was initially planned that Archduke Charles would launch a counter-attack against the French army on the same day, as Napoleon had hoped, but this was not carried out. On 25 October, Merveldt left Styria for Tyrol. On the same day, Austria launched its new offensive against the French at Ulm. Charles withdrew his army from the region for a third time at the Battle of Elchingen, under the overall command of the Austrian generals, Ferdinand and Friedrich Wilhelm of Jülich-Cleves-Berg. To prevent Archduke Charles from escaping from the battlefield, the commander of the Habsburg army, Archduke Charles, planned to occupy the fortress Linz; instead, he decided to force Franz von Hipper to surrender the city. However, as Charles moved to the south, Moreau arrived on the scene with additional soldiers – including the entire Imperial Guard – and defeated the Austrians at the Battle of Hohenlinden on 28 October. The loss of Linz resulted in Austria's complete defeat at Hohenlinden. In the meantime, the French Army of Observation and Preparedness was reorganized into the Army of the Danube under Feldzeugmeister (Colonel-General) Friedrich Freiherr von Hotze. The army was composed of the I, IV, VI, VI, VII, VIII and IX Corps. With reinforcements from Italy and France, it formed new battalions, companies, and squadrons in the Austrian army. On 17 November 1804, at the Battle of Jena-Auerstadt the Army of Silesia and the Army of Silesia joined forces, but by the time that the

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after the disastrous invasion of Russia in 1812. Napoleon's empire ultimately suffered complete military defeat in the 1813 – 14 campaigns, resulting in the restoration of the Bourbon monarchy in France. Although Napoleon made a spectacular return in 1815, known as the Hundred Days, his defeat at the Battle of Waterloo, the pursuit of his army and himself, his abdication and banishment to the Island of Saint Helena concluded the Napoleonic Wars.

= = Danube campaign = =

From 1803-06 the Third Coalition fought the First French Empire and its client states (see table at right). Although several naval battles determined control of the seas, the outcome of the war was decided on the continent, predominantly in two major land operations in the Danube valley: the Ulm campaign in the upper Danube and the Vienna campaign, in the middle Danube valley. Political conflicts in Vienna delayed Austria's entry into the Third Coalition until 1805. After hostilities of the War of the Second Coalition ended in 1801, Archduke <unk> emperor's <unk> advantage of the subsequent years of peace to develop a military restructuring plan. He carefully put this plan into effect beginning in 1803 – 04, but implementation was incomplete in 1805 when Karl Mack, Lieutenant Field Marshal and Quartermaster-General of the Army, implemented his own restructuring. Mack bypassed Charles ' methodical approach. Occurring in the field, Mack's plan also undermined the overall command and organizational structure. Regardless, Mack sent an enthusiastic report to Vienna on the military's readiness. Furthermore, after misreading Napoleon's maneuvers in Württemberg, Mack also reported to Vienna on the weakness of French dispositions. His reports convinced the war party advising the emperor, Francis II, to enter the conflict against France, despite Charles ' own advice to the contrary. Responding to the report and rampant anti-French fever in Vienna, Francis dismissed Charles from his post as generalissimo and appointed his <unk> brother-in-law, Archduke Ferdinand, as commander. The inexperienced Ferdinand was a poor choice of replacement for the capable Charles, having neither maturity nor aptitude for the assignment. Although Ferdinand retained nominal command, day-to-day decisions were placed in the hands of Mack, equally ill-suited for such an important assignment. When Mack was wounded early in the campaign, he was unable to take full charge of the army. Consequently, command further devolved to Lieutenant Field Marshal Karl Philipp, Prince of Schwarzenberg, an able cavalry officer but inexperienced in the command of such a large army.

= = = Road to Ulm = = =

The campaign in the upper Danube valley began in October, with several clashes in Swabia. Near the Bavarian town of Wertingen, 40 kilometers (25 mi) northwest of Augsburg, on 8 October the 1st Regiment of dragoons, part of Murat's Reserve Cavalry Corps, and grenadiers of Lannes ' V Corps surprised an Austrian force half its size. The Austrians were arrayed in a line and unable to form their defensive squares quickly enough to protect themselves from the 4,000 dragoons and 8,000 grenadiers. Nearly 3,000 Austrians were captured and over 400 were killed or wounded. A day later, at another small town, <unk> south of the Danube <unk> French 59th Regiment of the Line stormed a bridge over the Danube and, humiliatingly, chased two large Austrian columns toward Ulm. The campaign was not entirely bad news for Vienna. At Haslach, Johann von Klenau arranged his 25,000 infantry and cavalry in a prime defensive position and, on 11 October, the overly confident General of Division Pierre Dupont de l'Étang attacked Klenau's force with fewer than 8,000 men. The French lost 1,500 men killed and wounded. Aside from taking the Imperial Eagles and <unk> of the 15th and 17th Dragoons, Klenau's force also captured 900 men, 11 guns and 18 ammunition wagons. Klenau's victory was a singular success. On 14 October Mack sent two columns out of Ulm in preparation for a breakout to the north: one under Johann Sigismund Riesch headed toward Elchingen to secure the bridge there, and the other under Franz von Werneck went north with most of the heavy artillery. Recognizing the opportunity, Marshal Michel Ney hurried the rest of his VI Corps forward to re-establish contact with Dupont, who was still north of the Danube. In a two-pronged attack Ney sent one division to the south of Elchingen on the right bank of the Danube. This division began the assault at Elchingen. At the same time another division crossed the river to the east and moved west against Riesch's position. After clearing Austrian pickets from a bridge, the French attacked and captured a strategically located abbey at